MICHAEL TOPPER

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Current as of January 30, 2026

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Assistant Professor of Economics: *California State Polytechnic University, Pomona* Current

SSRC Criminal Justice Innovation Postdoctoral Fellow: *UC Irvine Affiliation* 2024-2025

EDUCATION

University of California, Santa Barbara: *PhD Economics* 2024

San Diego State University: *M.A. Economics* 2018

University of California, San Diego: *B.S. Mathematics/Economics* 2015

PUBLICATIONS

The Effects of Fraternity Moratoriums on Alcohol Offenses and Sexual Assaults
Journal of Human Resources, Vol. 60, Issue 6 1 Nov 2025 2025

I exploit variation in timing from 44 temporary university-wide halts on all fraternity activity with alcohol (moratoriums) across 37 universities over 2014-2019. I construct a novel data set, merging incident-level crime logs from university police departments to provide the first causal estimates of the effect of moratoriums on reports of alcohol offenses and sexual assaults. In particular, I find robust evidence that moratoriums decrease alcohol offenses by 26%. Additionally, I find suggestive evidence that moratoriums decrease reports of sexual assault on the weekends by 29%. However, I do not find evidence of long-term changes once the moratorium is lifted.

The Unintended Consequences of Policing Technology: Evidence from ShotSpotter *Accepted: Journal of Human Resources*
(with Toshio Ferrazares)

Technology is integral to police departments, automating officer tasks, but inherently changing their time allocation. We investigate this by studying ShotSpotter, a technology that automates gunfire detection. Following a detection, officers are dispatched to the scene, thereby reallocating their time. We leverage this shock to officers' time allocation using the rollout of ShotSpotter across Chicago police districts to study the effects on 911 call response. We find substantial consequences—officers are dispatched to calls slower (23%), arrive on-scene later (13%), and the probability of arrest is decreased 9%. Consequently, police departments must evaluate their resource capacities prior to implementing technologies.

WORKING PAPERS

In Progress: *"Gunshot Noise and Birth Outcomes"*
(with Anna Jaskiewicz)

Gun violence is ubiquitous across the United States, with gun-related deaths reaching an all-time high in 2021. The prevalence of gunfire results in loud and potentially stress-inducing sounds, which may adversely affect critical stages of in utero development. However, gunfire is largely unreported, creating a unique challenge for researchers to understand its consequences. In this paper, we mitigate this shortcoming by leveraging data from ShotSpotter—an acoustic gunshot technology which uses an array of sensors placed on city structures to detect the sound of gunfire. We combine this unique data source with the universe of births from nine California cities, each matched to a mother's residence. Using the variation in gunfire detections from ShotSpotter at the census-block level, we employ a difference-in-differences methodology and find that gunshot noise creates substantial increases in very low birth weight ($<$ 1,500 grams) and very pre-term births ($<$ 32 weeks). These effects are driven by times of the day when mothers are likely to be at-home, and are particularly concentrated among mothers with low levels of education. These results suggest that gunshot noise is a major factor contributing to the income inequities in pregnancy outcomes.

In Progress: *"Police Efficiency and Discretion: Learn-by-Doing"*

I leverage the quasi-random variation of police officer exposure to different policing duties during their field training to understand how on-the-job training can affect worker efficiency and discretion in a high-stakes environment. Using a novel dataset combining every dispatch from Chicago over a 5-year period with each officer's training information, I find that police officers who receive high exposure to specific tasks during training perform these tasks faster (2%), and make fewer arrests (4%) in their first year post-training. These results are driven by low-priority incidents, and the effects persist throughout an officer's first year post-training in the field. Taken together, these findings imply that scarce officer resources can potentially be mitigated by increased on-the-job training.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record: *California State Polytechnic University, Pomona*

- EC 2201 Introductory Microeconomics - (Fall 2025, Spring 2026)
- EC 4406 Mathematical Economics - (Fall 2025)
- EC 4990 Data Wrangling with R - (Spring 2026)
- EC 5550 Microeconomic Analysis—Graduate Level - (Spring 2026)

Instructor of Record: *UC Santa Barbara*, *San Diego State University*, and *Santa Barbara City College*

- Econ 199RA Data Hack - (UCSB: Spring 2022, Winter 2024)
- Econ 102: Introductory Microeconomics - (SDSU: Fall 2017/Spring 2018)
- Econ 101: Introductory Microeconomics - (SBCC: Spring 2025)
- Econ 102: Introductory Macroeconomics - (SBCC: Spring 2025)

Teaching Assistant: *University of California, Santa Barbara* and *San Diego State University*

- Introductory Microeconomics- (UCSB: Fall 2018/Winter 2019)
- Introductory Macroeconomics - (UCSB: Spring 2019, 2020, 2023/Winter 2022, 2023)
- Introductory Econometrics A - (UCSB: Fall 2019/Winter 2020/Summer 2021)
- Introductory Econometrics B - (UCSB: Summer 2023)
- Data Wrangling in Economics - (UCSB: Fall 2020, 2021, 2022)
- Public Finance - (UCSB: Spring 2024)
- Introduction to Research in STEM, Humanities, and Social Sciences - (UCSB: Summer 2023)
- Introductory Microeconomics - (SDSU: Fall 2016)
- Introductory Econometrics - (SDSU: Spring 2017)

Course Curriculum Creator: *University of California, Santa Barbara*

- Main contributor of course curriculum for Econ 145: Data Wrangling in Economics and its graduate counterpart, Econ 245, using the R programming language.

Undergraduate Research Advisor: *University of California Santa Barbara*

- Advisor for student Terry Cheng for undergraduate economics research.

Advanced Math Lab Tutor: *Santa Barbara City College*

- Tutored Calculus for Engineers I-III, Linear Algebra, Differential Equations, and Elementary Statistics at Santa Barbara Community College's walk-in mathematics lab.

TEACHING RECOGNITION

Academic Senate Outstanding Teaching Assistant: *University of California, Santa Barbara*

- Nominated: Fall 2019 (Introductory Econometrics)
- Nominated: Fall 2020 (Data Wrangling for Economics)

GSA Excellence in Teaching Award: *University of California, Santa Barbara*

- Nominated: Fall 2022

UCSB Economics Department Teaching Award: *University of California, Santa Barbara*

- Awarded: Fall 2021

TEXTBOOK

Data Wrangling for Economists (with Danny Klinenberg)

- This textbook (see here) was written as a guide for economists in both the undergraduate and PhD program to assist with the courses Econ 145/245. The book is a free online source, and is constantly undergoing revision.
- Chapter 8 used in CSU San Luis Obispo course: GSE 570 Collaborative Software Development for Economists

SOFTWARE

R Package: panelsummary

- Creates publication-quality regression tables that have multiple panels. Available on CRAN. Over 4.5k downloads. Click here for the package website.

ACADEMIC RECOGNITION

M.C. Madhaven Prize Outstanding Graduate Student: *San Diego State University*

- Awarded annually by the San Diego State Department of Economics to the Outstanding Graduating Masters Student.

The Weintraub Paper Award: *San Diego State University*

- Excellence in writing about Economics: "Do Donald Trump Rallies Cause More Violence?"

Terhune Scholarship: *San Diego State University*

PRESENTATIONS

V.I.C.E. Seminar	2024
Chicago Crime Lab	2024
Western Economic Association	2023, 2025
All-California Labor Conference	2023
San Diego State Economics Department Seminar	2023
Applied UCSB Microeconomics Lunch	2023

EXTERNAL AWARDS AND PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

External Grants: *Extended Shifts and Productivity* (Arnold Ventures RFP $195,505)

Referee: *Economic Inquiry*

University Service: *Professional Development Committee* (Cal Poly Pomona: 2025-2026)

WORK EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant for Dr. Heather Royer: *University of California, Santa Barbara*	2020 - 2021
Appfolio: *Value Added Services: SaaS Intern*	2015 - 2016
Research Assistant for Dr. Steve Levkoff: *University of California, San Diego*	2014 - 2015

REFERENCES:

Professor Heather Royer
UC Santa Barbara
Committee Chair
(805) 893-8830
royer@econ.ucsb.edu

Associate Professor Kevin Schnepel
Simon Fraser University
Committee Member
N/A
kevin_schnepel@sfu.ca

Professor Dick Startz
UC Santa Barbara
Committee Member
(805) 893-2895
startz@ucsb.edu

ADDITIONAL INFO

Technical: R, Python, ArcGIS, LaTeX, STATA, MatLab

Areas of Focus: Economics of Crime, Health Economics, Labor Economics

Out of Office: Personal Food Critic, One-man Rock Band, Basketball Extraordinaire